

NEXT UP

PITTSBURGH PIRATES / 2027 PLAYER DEVELOPMENT OUTLOOK

Three overlooked contributors who could shape the next step

By Daniel Hedrick • Independent baseball operations analysis • October 2026

Pittsburgh’s path forward will not depend exclusively on major acquisitions. Developing cost-controlled contributors can also create flexibility to address needs elsewhere. This report examines three different internal opportunities: optimizing a pitcher’s role, maximizing a versatile hitter’s roster value, and unlocking a power bat. These are developmental hypotheses—not predictions or claims about the club’s internal evaluations.

01 / KHRISTIAN CURTIS

THE HYPOTHESIS • Could a streamlined relief role unlock more swing-and-miss?

21	14.9%	3.73	.196
MLB IP	MLB K%	MLB xERA	MLB xBA

Curtis’s early major league profile presents an intriguing contrast: his strikeout rate has dropped relative to his minor league track record, yet the draft data suggest he has limited the quality of contact against him. Rather than assuming a relief conversion will solve that gap, Pittsburgh could test whether a narrower pitch mix and shorter outings improve his bat-missing ability.

The Luke Weaver comparison is a pitch-design reference, not a career projection. Curtis has worked on a cut-ride fastball reportedly reaching 96 mph with roughly 18 inches of vertical break. MLB Pipeline also reported a 45% miss rate on his changeup in 2025. Those characteristics justify examining whether his changeup deserves greater emphasis, but its usage should depend on command, platoon results, sequencing and whether the miss-rate definitions are comparable.

ORGANIZATIONAL QUESTION

In a relief-only trial, does increasing changeup usage improve Curtis’s K–BB% and effectiveness against opposite-handed hitters without compromising command? Compare his results with a starter/depth role before treating the bullpen as the preferred outcome.

02 / DUCE GOURSON

THE HYPOTHESIS • Can on-base skill and versatility create an inexpensive bench asset?

.247/.377/.396	13	38	.773
2026 MiLB slash	2026 MiLB HR	2026 MiLB SB	2026 MiLB OPS

Gourson offers a more conservative version of the multiposition-player concept often associated with Ben Zobrist. His realistic role comparison is closer to an on-base-oriented utility contributor than an everyday All-Star. In 2026, he combined a .377 on-base percentage with 38 stolen bases, making his plate approach and baserunning meaningful parts of the evaluation.

MLB Pipeline notes that Gourson has played second base, third base and first base, with possible future exposure to the outfield corners. That positional coverage could help Pittsburgh carry a flexible bench while directing payroll or roster space toward higher-impact needs. The remaining questions are whether his contact quality holds up against major league pitching and whether he can defend enough positions at a reliable level.

ORGANIZATIONAL QUESTION

Could Gourson fill a left-handed, multiposition bench role without creating an offensive or defensive liability? Evaluate strikeout rate, production against right-handed pitching, performance by position and outfield readiness before assuming he can cover an expanded utility role.

03 / JHOSTYNXON GARCÍA

THE HYPOTHESIS • Can elite raw power become usable production against MLB sequencing?

113 mph	35%	34%	21
2025 max exit velo	2025 AAA chase rate	2025 AAA whiff rate	2025 MiLB HR

García fits a high-variance power-hitter archetype that is easy to imagine changing a short series. But postseason hot streaks by hitters such as Randy Arozarena or Mark Vientos are illustrations, not evidence that García is especially likely to replicate them. The actionable question is whether Pittsburgh can unlock his power often enough to justify a consistent role.

Baseball America reports that García reached 113 mph in maximum exit velocity in 2025 but also carried a 35% chase rate and 34% whiff rate at Triple-A. Its scouting report identifies a steep swing path that can leave him vulnerable above the belt, while noting work to flatten the swing and improve decisions. His right-handed power and outfield ability provide multiple routes to value, but better pitch recognition is essential to expanding his offensive ceiling.

The research identifies a .706 slugging percentage against 95+ mph pitches at Triple-A in 2025 and a 51.2% MLB whiff rate against breaking balls in 2026. Those splits are intriguing, but should not be treated as conclusive without their exact sample sizes and pitch-type filters. Velocity alone is not equivalent to facing postseason-caliber pitch location and sequencing.

ORGANIZATIONAL QUESTION

Can targeted breaking-ball recognition work reduce chase without sacrificing damage on hittable pitches? Track out-of-zone chase, in-zone contact and barrel production by pitch type across meaningful samples. A fourth-outfielder outcome could still be valuable even if the contact limitations persist.

THE ROSTER-CONSTRUCTION CONNECTION

These three cases represent different forms of internal value. A reliable Curtis relief role could reduce the need to acquire bullpen depth; a versatile Gourson could increase bench flexibility; and a more selective García could supply affordable right-handed power. None is guaranteed. Together, however, they illustrate why player-development decisions should inform Pittsburgh's offseason resource allocation—not simply follow it.

RESEARCH NOTES & SOURCES

Statistics are identified by season and level. All projections and proposed organizational tests represent independent analysis.

MLB Pipeline — Khristian Curtis scouting report <https://www.mlb.com/milb/prospects/pirates/khristian-curtis-694753>

MLB Pipeline — Duce Gourson scouting report <https://www.mlb.com/milb/prospects/pirates/duce-gourson-701546>

MiLB — Duce Gourson 2026 statistics <https://www.milb.com/player/duce-gourson-701546>

Baseball America — Jhostynxon García scouting report <https://www.baseballamerica.com/players/18649-jhostynxon-garcia/>

Baseball Savant — García MLB pitch-level data <https://baseballsavant.mlb.com/savant-player/jhostynxon-garcia-691373>

FanGraphs — Khristian Curtis player statistics

<https://www.fangraphs.com/players/khristian-curtis/sa3023473/stats/pitching>

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<https://www.fangraphs.com/players/ethan-gourson/sa3025248/stats/batting>

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